

The Continuity Architecture

Why Succession and Retention Planning Are Not Only Possible in Trinidad and Tobago's Mixed-Employment Organisations, But Essential

A companion paper to *The Governance-Psychology Gap*

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About the Author

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Executive Summary

In meeting rooms across Trinidad and Tobago, a particular sentence is quietly costing organisations their best people and their institutional memory. It usually sounds like this: *“We cannot really do succession planning or retention planning here. The public service rules tie our hands, and we have too many different kinds of staff, public servants, contract officers, temporary workers, all mixed together.”*

It is a reasonable-sounding statement. It is also wrong. Not partly wrong. Structurally wrong. This paper sets out to disprove it, using behavioural science, information governance practice, and the documented behaviour of the largest merit-based public services on earth.

The core error is a confusion between two different things: succession planning and succession appointment. The rules that constrain Trinidad and Tobago’s public bodies govern who may be *appointed* to a post. They say almost nothing about who may be **developed**, what knowledge may be **captured**, or how people may be **retained**. Appointment is roughly the final five percent of the work. The other ninety-five percent, developing capability and protecting institutional knowledge, sits entirely within any organisation’s control, despite its mix of employment types.

Seen this way, the belief that “the rules make it impossible” is not a fact about the rules at all. It is a behavioural artifact. It is what the **Governance-Psychology Gap** looks like in the talent domain, a formal structure being used as permission to avoid the harder human work. And it is expensive, because in a country that has lost a striking share of its skilled population to migration, knowledge that walks out the door rarely walks back in.

Key Findings at a Glance

- ▶ **Planning is not appointment.** Public service rules constrain the appointment decision, not the development of people or the capture of knowledge. The constraint applies to a thin final layer, not to the work that creates continuity.
- ▶ **It is already done at scale.** The United States federal government and the United Kingdom Civil Service, two of the most rule-bound, tenure-protected, politically neutral merit services in existence, both run formal succession and talent programmes inside their merit systems. Trinidad and Tobago’s public service descends from the same Westminster tradition.
- ▶ **Mixed employment is the argument for, not against.** Contract and temporary staff are, by definition, the highest flight-risk holders of institutional knowledge. The more varied the tenure mix, the greater the continuity risk, and the more essential the planning becomes.

- ▶ **Retention is relational, not structural.** People do not stay because of their employment category. They stay because of the psychological contract- autonomy, growth, recognition, and trust. These levers are available to every employer regardless of the terms on the paper.
- ▶ **The belief has a price.** Replacing a leader can cost around two times the salary; institutional knowledge loss compounds it; and roughly four in ten people who quit say they could have been kept.

1. The Conceptual Error: Planning Is Not Appointment

Start with the precise claim, because precision is where it falls apart. The objection bundles three separate activities into one and then declares the whole bundle impossible. Untie the bundle and the impossibility disappears.

Succession and retention work is best understood as three distinct layers, each with a different relationship to the rules. I call this the **Continuity Architecture**.

Tier 1 - Knowledge Continuity

This is the deliberate capture of what people know before they leave; documented procedures, decision logic, process maps, relationship registers, and properly classified records. No public service rule anywhere prevents an organisation from writing down how its work is done. This tier is one hundred percent within the organisation's control. It is also, not incidentally, an information governance discipline, capturing institutional knowledge is the same skill set as protecting and classifying sensitive information. Industry research finds that more than half of organisations struggle to transfer knowledge from departing staff, and the problem is most acute in legal and records-heavy environments (Robert Half, 2026).

Tier 2 - Capability Continuity

This is the development of people so that capability exists when a gap opens; cross-training, stretch assignments, structured shadowing, coaching, and competency frameworks. Again, no rule prevents an organisation from developing anyone, of any employment type. Developing a contract officer's capability does not promise them a post; it builds bench strength the organisation can draw on. This tier is roughly ninety-five percent within control.

Tier 3 - Appointment Continuity

This is the actual filling of a post when it falls vacant. This, and only this, is where the public service rules genuinely apply. And even here the rules shape *how* an appointment is made, through merit and due process, not *whether* the organisation prepared for it.

The Reframe

The mistake is throwing away the ninety-five percent you control because of the five percent you do not. Organisations abandon knowledge capture and people development, both fully permitted, because the appointment decision is constrained. That is not a legal limitation. It is a behavioural decision dressed in the language of compliance. The rule becomes a permission slip to skip the harder, human work.

This is the talent-domain expression of the *Governance-Psychology Gap*; the space between the formal structure and the human behaviour around it. The structure here, the merit appointment system, is doing exactly what it should. The gap is behavioural, and it is closable.

2. Proof at Scale: Merit-Based Services Already Do This

If merit-based, tenure-protected public services truly could not plan succession, we would expect the largest of them to have given up on it. The opposite is true.

The United States federal government runs a formal Strategic Leadership Succession Management Model through its Office of Personnel Management. The model walks agencies through forecasting future needs, assessing current talent, and building leadership pipelines, and it does so explicitly within and in compliance with merit system principles (U.S. Office of Personnel Management, n.d.). This is a civil service of more than two million employees, bound by some of the most detailed personnel law in the world, and it treats succession planning as standard practice.

The United Kingdom Civil Service operates structured talent management across government, including dedicated succession planning for its most senior roles and a Leadership and Talent Board that reviews the leadership pipeline. Its Success Profiles framework is designed precisely to keep selection merit-based while still developing a deliberate pipeline of future leaders (UK Civil Service, 2020).

Why This Settles the Question

Trinidad and Tobago's public service is modelled on the same Westminster tradition as the United Kingdom and Canada, built on political neutrality and merit-based appointment through service commissions. The two largest services in that tradition both plan succession inside their merit rules. The claim that merit rules make succession planning impossible is therefore not difficult to disprove. It is disproven at the largest possible scale, by the very systems Trinidad and Tobago's own public service is descended from.

Closer to home, an Inter-American Development Bank diagnostic of Trinidad and Tobago's civil service identified human resource planning, professional development, and the ability to attract, retain, and motivate staff as central to state capacity (Underwood, 2018). The diagnostic frames these as functions to be strengthened, not functions that are foreclosed by the system's design. The gap it describes is one of practice, not of legal possibility.

3. Mixed Employment Is the Argument For, Not Against

The second half of the objection, that a mix of public servants, contract officers, and temporary staff makes planning impossible, inverts the logic of risk. The mixed model is not the reason to avoid continuity planning. It is the single strongest reason to do it.

Consider who actually holds the flight risk. A contract or temporary officer is, by the structure of their engagement, more likely to leave and on shorter notice than a tenured public servant. If that person holds critical institutional knowledge, and in lean public bodies they very often do, then their departure is a continuity event waiting to happen. An organisation with many contract staff that declines to plan for their exit is not managing risk. It is concentrating it.

"We have too many contract staff to plan for continuity" is logically equivalent to "the building has too much fire to install sprinklers." The objection names the exact condition that makes the intervention urgent.

There is also a behavioural dimension that the structural objection misses entirely. Different employment types do not require the abandonment of retention. They require that you pull *different psychological levers*, which is the subject of the next section. The presence of contract staff changes the *how* of retention. It does not remove the *whether*.

4. Retention Is Relational, Not Structural

The deepest assumption inside the original claim is that retention is a structural matter, that you keep people by giving them permanent posts and competitive pay, and that where the rules limit those things, retention is impossible. Behavioural science does not support this. Retention is, first and foremost, relational.

The psychological contract

Every working relationship contains an unwritten set of mutual expectations, what the employee believes they are owed and what they feel obliged to give in return. This is the **psychological contract**, first named by Argyris and developed extensively by Denise Rousseau (Argyris, 1960; Rousseau, 1989, 1995). It comes in different forms. A **transactional** contract is short-term and purely monetary, low loyalty, low discretionary effort. A **relational** contract is built on trust, growth, and mutual investment, and it produces markedly higher engagement and retention.

Here is the point that dissolves the objection; contract and temporary employees default to a transactional contract only when the organisation treats them transactionally. When an employer deliberately invests in a contract officer's development, recognises their contribution, and includes them in the mission, the contract shifts toward the relational, and so does their commitment. Research on temporary and agency workers confirms that those engaged through intrinsic, developmental motivation show substantially stronger commitment and wellbeing than those treated as disposable labour (Sobral, Chambel, & Castanheira, 2021). The employment category is the starting condition. The psychological contract is the variable you control.

What actually drives staying

Self-Determination Theory identifies three needs that, when met, produce durable intrinsic motivation—autonomy, competence, and relatedness (Ryan & Deci, 2000). None of the three is governed by employment type or pay scale. A contract officer given genuine ownership of their work (autonomy), real development (competence), and inclusion in a team with shared purpose (relatedness) has powerful reasons to stay that no rulebook restricts.

The evidence base reinforces this. Gallup finds that roughly forty-two percent of people who left voluntarily say their organisation could have done something to keep them, and that recognition, growth, and the quality of the manager relationship are decisive (Gallup, 2024). Psychological safety, the confidence that one can speak up, raise concerns, and admit error without disproportionate

consequence, is a further retention driver and, as argued in the companion whitepaper, a governance control in its own right (Edmondson, 2019).

The Retention Reframe

You were told retention depends on what the organisation can offer on paper. It depends far more on what the organisation does in practice; how it develops people, how it recognises them, and whether it is safe to be honest. Those levers are available to every employer, for every category of staff, under every set of rules.

5. The Cost of the Belief

The “we cannot do this” belief is not cost-neutral. It is one of the most expensive positions an organisation can hold, and the cost lands in three places; replacement, lost knowledge, and a national talent pool that is already thin.



Replacement cost. Gallup estimates replacement at roughly two times salary for leaders and managers, around eighty percent for technical roles, and forty percent for frontline staff (Gallup, 2024). The Society for Human Resource Management has long put the all-in figure at six to nine months of the role’s salary (SHRM, 2017). At national scale the numbers are vast, the Work Institute estimated that United States employers spent close to nine hundred billion dollars replacing people who quit in a single year (Work Institute, 2024).

Knowledge cost. This is the cost the belief hides best, because it never appears on a budget line. When an experienced officer leaves without structured handover, the organisation loses relationships, judgement, and undocumented processes that no quick replacement can restore. More than half of organisations report difficulty capturing this knowledge, and the difficulty is highest in legal and records-intensive settings (Robert Half, 2026). Poorly managed leadership transitions alone have

been estimated to cost large firms tens of billions in lost value annually (Harvard Business Review, 2021).

The national context sharpens all of it. Trinidad and Tobago has historically lost an extraordinary share of its skilled population to emigration. One widely cited analysis found that the country had lost roughly seventy-nine percent of its tertiary-educated citizens to migration (Mishra, 2006), and the International Organization for Migration estimated that around twenty-nine percent of nationals were living abroad as of 2020 (IOM, 2021). In that environment, an organisation that does not capture knowledge and retain people deliberately is not facing a temporary inconvenience when someone leaves. It is often facing a permanent loss, because the replacement talent has frequently left the country altogether.

The belief that succession and retention planning cannot be done is not a neutral position.

It is an active decision to absorb replacement costs, surrender institutional knowledge, and expose the organisation to a talent market that is structurally short of the very people it will need to rehire.

6. A Continuity Architecture You Can Build Now

The following actions are sequenced by control and speed. They are deliberately mapped to the three tiers, and every one of them is available to organisations in Trinidad and Tobago today, regardless of its mix of public servants, contract officers, and temporary staff, and without touching the appointment rules at all.

Begin with Tier 1, because it is fully in your control

- 1. Map critical-knowledge roles.** Identify the small number of positions whose sudden vacancy would most disrupt operations. Criticality is about knowledge concentration and replacement difficulty, not seniority. A long-serving contract officer can be more critical than a recent permanent hire.
- 2. Require structured knowledge capture for those roles.** Documented procedures, decision logic, key relationships, and properly classified records. Treat this as an information governance task, because that is exactly what it is.
- 3. Institute overlap and handover protocols.** Where a departure is foreseeable, build in a structured handover window. Where it is not, the documentation from step two carries the load.

Move to Tier 2, which the rules also leave open

4. **Cross-train deliberately.** Ensure no critical function rests on a single person. Cross-training builds bench strength and is permitted for every employment category.
5. **Develop people regardless of tenure type.** Stretch assignments, shadowing, and coaching develop capability without promising a post. Development is not appointment.
6. **Use competency frameworks for critical roles.** Structured, behaviour-based criteria make readiness visible and selection defensible, the same logic the UK Success Profiles framework uses to stay merit-based while building a pipeline.

Strengthen retention through the psychological contract

7. **Shift contract and temporary staff toward a relational contract.** Invest in their growth, recognise their contribution, and include them in the mission. Commitment follows investment, not employment category.
8. **Build the three drivers of intrinsic motivation.** Autonomy, competence, and relatedness. None requires a change to pay scale or tenure.
9. **Make recognition and psychological safety routine.** Recognition is among the strongest and cheapest retention levers, and a psychologically safe climate retains your talent, and surfaces the early warnings that protect the organisation.

Sequencing Note

Tier 1 delivers the fastest protection at the lowest cost and with zero rule friction, so it comes first. Tier 2 compounds over time. Tier 3, the appointment itself, is where the rules live, and by the time you reach it you will have done the ninety-five percent of the work that actually determines whether the organisation has continuity. The rules were never the obstacle. They simply mark the boundary of a much smaller territory than the objection assumed.

The Bottom Line

The claim that succession and retention planning cannot be done in organisations in Trinidad and Tobago governed by public service rules and staffed by mixed employment types does not survive contact with the evidence. It confuses planning with appointment. It ignores that the largest merit services on earth plan succession inside their rules. It misreads a mixed workforce as a barrier when

it is in fact the clearest signal that the work is needed. And it assumes retention is structural when behavioural science shows it is relational.

What looks like a legal limitation is, on inspection, a behavioural choice. That is the recurring shape of the *Governance-Psychology Gap* - a formal structure mistaken for the whole story, with the human work left undone in its shadow. The structure is not the problem. The space beside it is. And that space can be closed, deliberately, starting now, from both sides at once.

Read the Companion Whitepaper

This paper extends the argument first set out in *The Governance-Psychology Gap: Why Trinidad & Tobago's Organisations Are Exposed, And What To Do About It*. The whitepaper develops the central framework, the distance between formal governance and the human culture that determines whether it is followed, and is available, with the accompanying diagnostic tools, at:

ayoolaclarke-prescott.github.io

Engage

For governance-psychology audits, succession and retention strategy, organisational training, or speaking engagements, contact ayo.stratminds@gmail.com or visit ayoolaclarke-prescott.github.io.

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